

CORTORA

Standard Operating Procedure for Card Network Disputes

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This Standard Operating Procedure describes how Payments Operations and Payments Specialists should handle chargebacks — disputes raised by a customer directly with their card issuer or bank rather than through Cortora's own refund process.

1. What Is a Chargeback

A chargeback occurs when a customer disputes a transaction with their card issuer, which reverses the transaction and withdraws the funds from Cortora pending a review process. Chargebacks differ from refunds: a refund is initiated by Cortora through its own systems, while a chargeback is initiated by the customer's bank and carries additional evidentiary and timing requirements set by the payment network.

2. Chargeback Lifecycle

Status	Meaning
CHARGEBACK_INITIATED	The card issuer has notified Cortora of a dispute and withdrawn the funds.
EVIDENCE_SUBMITTED	Cortora has submitted supporting evidence to contest the dispute.
REVIEW_IN_PROGRESS	The card issuer's review found in Cortora's favour; funds are returned to Cortora.
DISPUTE_LOST	The card issuer's review found in the customer's favour; the reversal stands.
DISPUTE_ACCEPTED	Cortora chose not to contest the dispute.

3. Common Chargeback Reason Codes

Reason category	Description	Typical evidence to gather
Product not received	Customer claims the item never arrived.	Carrier tracking and proof of delivery; prior support correspondence about the order.
Product not as described / defective	Customer claims the item is materially different or faulty.	Product listing details; any prior return or warranty case for the same order.
Unauthorized transaction	Cardholder states they did not make or authorize the purchase.	Account login history, delivery address, and any identity verification completed at checkout.
Duplicate transaction	Cardholder identifies what they believe is a duplicate charge.	Full transaction history for the order, cross-checked against the Payment Operations SOP duplicate investigation.

Reason category	Description	Typical evidence to gather
Credit not processed	Cardholder states a promised refund was never received.	Refund execution record and resulting payment status.

4. Immediate Steps on Receiving a Chargeback Notice

- Locate the original order and payment record and confirm the transaction identifier matches the disputed transaction.
- Check whether a refund was already issued for this transaction before the chargeback was filed; if so, this significantly changes the evidence to submit.
- Check whether an open support case already exists for this order; if so, review it for context before responding.
- Record the chargeback deadline provided by the payment network; evidence must be submitted before this deadline or the dispute is automatically lost.

5. Deciding Whether to Contest

A chargeback should generally be contested when Cortora holds evidence that directly rebuts the reason code, for example:

- 'Product not received' with a carrier proof-of-delivery record showing successful delivery to the correct address.
- 'Unauthorized transaction' with strong account verification signals and a delivery address matching the cardholder's known address.
- 'Credit not processed' where the payment record clearly shows a REFUNDED status predating the dispute.

A chargeback should generally be accepted rather than contested when Cortora's own evidence is weak or absent, when the underlying issue reflects a genuine service failure (e.g. confirmed non-delivery with no proof of delivery), or when contesting would cost more in fees and effort than the transaction value justifies, subject to Payments Operations guidance on threshold amounts.

6. Evidence Submission

- Compile evidence strictly relevant to the specific reason code cited; irrelevant evidence can weaken a case.
- Include order, payment, delivery, and any relevant support case records with clear timestamps.
- Submit evidence through the approved payment provider dispute portal before the stated deadline.
- Record the submission in the case, including what was submitted and the expected review timeframe.

7. Interaction with Refunds

Once a chargeback has been initiated for a transaction, do not process a separate refund for the same transaction while the dispute is open, since this can result in the customer being credited twice. If a refund had already been issued before the chargeback was filed, this fact should be the centrepiece of the contest evidence rather than being treated as unrelated history.

8. Repeated Chargebacks on One Account

An account with multiple chargebacks, particularly disputes that Cortora's evidence suggests were unwarranted, should be flagged to Risk & Trust for review under the Fraud & Risk Policy. This is a risk signal distinct from an ordinary customer service issue and should not be resolved solely at the payments level.

9. Role of OpsPilot

OpsPilot may compile the relevant order, payment, delivery, and case evidence for a chargeback, identify the applicable reason category from Section 3, and draft a recommended contest-or-accept position with supporting rationale. A Payments Specialist must review and approve the recommendation and the final evidence package before submission; OpsPilot does not submit evidence to the payment provider directly.

10. Related Documents

- Payment Operations SOP — governs standard payment case handling and refund execution.
- Refund Policy — governs refund eligibility referenced when comparing to a chargeback claim.
- Fraud & Risk Policy — governs repeated or suspicious chargeback patterns.

Synthetic environment notice: Cortora, its employees, customers, policies, and operational records are fictional and created solely for the OpsPilot engineering project.